T. Rex Footprints Show How Fast It Walked

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Four **fossil** footprints are helping scientists learn about a dinosaur. They are the first known set of tracks likely left by an adult **Tyrannosaurus rex**. A **trackway** is three or more footprints in a row. This one is 7 meters long. The space between the prints shows the giant walked at about 1.6 meters per second. That is a quick walking **pace** for us. 'Finding an adult **trackway** is cool,' says Peter Falkingham, a scientist who studies **fossils**. The tracks were found by Kent Hups, a high school teacher. He found them in North Dakota last year. The first print was huge: 80 **centimeters** across, with three toes. The tracks are about 66.5 million years old. Scientists used the length of the steps and the size of the body to guess the speed. The prints are **worn**, so the speed is a guess. A fifth step may be hidden in the hill. The team waits for nature to wear away the rock. 'I can't wait to get back out there and keep looking for more,' Hups says.

Word Treasure

fossil -- A fossil is the remains of a living thing preserved in rock.
trackway -- A trackway is three or more footprints in a row.
Tyrannosaurus rex -- Tyrannosaurus rex was a giant meat-eating dinosaur.
centimeters -- Centimeters are small units for measuring length, one hundredth of a meter.
pace -- A pace is the speed at which someone walks.
worn -- Worn means rubbed away or smoothed down over time.

Background you need

A fossil is the remains of a living thing preserved in rock, and footprints can fossilize too.

Scientists study fossil tracks to learn how big a dinosaur was and how fast it walked.

Tyrannosaurus rex was a giant meat-eating dinosaur that lived about 66 million years ago.

Break it down

WHO: Peter Falkingham, a scientist who studies fossils, and Kent Hups, a high school teacher who found the tracks.

WHAT: Four fossil footprints, the first known set of tracks likely left by an adult Tyrannosaurus rex, show how fast the giant walked.

WHERE: In North Dakota, where Kent Hups found them last year.

WHY: Because the space between the prints and the length of the steps let scientists guess the dinosaur's walking speed.

Why it matters

Dinosaur footprints are like clues from a crime scene, and learning to read them shows how scientists turn small clues into big discoveries.

Test what you remember

1. How many fossil footprints are in the trackway?

- (A) Five
- (B) Four
- (C) Three
- (D) Seven

2. What is a trackway?

- (A) A hole in a hill
- (B) A dinosaur's nest
- (C) Three or more footprints in a row
- (D) A pile of old bones

3. How long is the trackway?

- (A) 66.5 meters
- (B) 7 meters
- (C) 1.6 meters
- (D) 80 centimeters

4. How fast did the giant walk?

- (A) About 1.6 meters per second
- (B) About 66.5 meters per second
- (C) About 80 centimeters per second
- (D) About 7 meters per second

5. How old are the tracks?

- (A) About 66.5 million years old
- (B) About 7 million years old
- (C) About 80 million years old
- (D) About 1.6 million years old

6. Who found the tracks?

- (A) Peter Falkingham, a scientist
- (B) A team of NASA volunteers
- (C) Kent Hups, a high school teacher
- (D) A group of students

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Peter Falkingham: Says finding an adult trackway is cool.**
2. **Kent Hups: Says he can't wait to get back out there and keep looking for more.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):